powerful team could, and would, be built around Strauss, KP, Paul Collingwood, Ian Bell, Matt Prior, Swann, Broad and Anderson. Jonathan Trott was waiting in the wings to make an indelible mark by scoring a maiden century at the Oval to set up the series win.

The skill of leadership is to respect the stridency and experience of senior players while nurturing younger members of the group who might not have the confidence to be vocal. There is no Utopian solution, but when it came to team building, we set great store by actions rather than words. We had the honesty to concede we were nowhere near our capacity.

We split into groups of four or five, with the task of returning to the group with our vision of what we wanted to be. The seeds had already been planted, subtly, by the management group, but the players felt empowered. When shortcomings were pointed out, they were couched not as accusations but as evidence-based reflections.

It was a democratically led dictatorship, a contradiction in terms that felt perfectly normal from the moment Andy and Straussy, in conjunction with team psychologist Mark Bawden and statistician Nathan Leamon, put things in black and white. They provided the parameters for our professed ambition, of becoming number one.

Our bowlers were performing close to the capacity required of a world-leading team. As a side we were conceding 2.9 runs an over; the target was just under 2.7. Our batsmen collectively averaged 37; we had a bigger gap to bridge, since that would need to be improved to around 45 if we were to fulfil our objective.

Nathan, known as ‘Numbers’ to all and sundry, loved this sort of stuff. He wasn’t, and isn’t, your average geek. A former maths teacher with eight, largely self-taught A levels, he played rugby league for Cambridge University, wrote poetry and had a novel, which centred on a dysfunctional Test dressing room, published in 2017. Hmmm …

As vice-captain, I had been able to play a minor role in challenging him during the formation of the strategy. I played devil’s advocate, insisting he was merely stating the obvious in numerical form. His response was swift and effective: he produced a series of potentially positive outcomes in the forthcoming Ashes series, ranging from a 5–0 whitewash to a narrow 2–1 victory, and extrapolated the consequences.

He calculated it would take between two and three years to become world number one, if results went the way he expected, and we delivered